Salty Kitchen Episode #1: Sopes y Aguas Frescas

Antojitos Mexicanos is a broad category of food that is usually enjoyed in the streets and mercados of Mexico year-round. Some popular Antojitos include: El Tamal, Guajolota (torta de tamal), Tlacoyos, Huaraches, Gorditas, Pambazo, Torta, and many more. Today we will learn how to make **sopes**, also known as **picaditas**.



The name “sope” comes from the nahuatl word *tzopitl*, which means picado (chopped). This is a prehispanic dish traditionally eaten with refried beans, chopped lettuce, cheese and salsa. Nowadays you can also find them with a “guiso” on top, such as tinga or potatoes and chorizo.



Aguas Frescas are a tradition from the Aztecs. During their journeys they would chop fruits, and grind flowers, adding water to quench their thirst. Nowadays, Aguas Frescas is a category of drinks prepared with fruits or seeds, ice, and sugar; the most common ones are Lime & Chia, Horchata, Jamaica and Tamarind. Fruit based aguas frescas include: orange, watermelon, papaya, zapote, strawberry, pineapple, mango, jobo (hog plumb), guava, ganabana (sourop), maracuya, xoconostle, chilacayota, and many more.

Today we will learn how to make “Agua de Jamaica” made with hibiscus flowers. Jamaica is a red drink characterized by a tart flavor that is balanced by the sugar in it. If this is your first time making it, **beware** of the jamaica concentrate, as it can stain your counters!

Ingredients Makes ~10 Sopes:

Agua Fresca:
- Hibiscus Flower 20-25 gr / 1 cup
- Cane Sugar ~150 gr / ¾ cup
- Water 1.5 L / ~ 4 ⅓ cups + 1 L
- Ice

Sopes:
For the Masa:
- Masa Harina (Most common brand: Maseca) - 1 heaping cup
- Warm Water - 1 to 1 ½ cups
- Oil or Lard (to cook the sopes) - 1-2 cups (OPTIONAL)

For the beans:
- Cooked Beans (pinto or black) - 2 cups
- Oil or Lard (to refry the beans) - 2-3 Tbsp
- White onion chopped ¼

For the Meat:
- Chopped Meat / Ground Beef - 1 Lbs **NOTE:** Can sub with potatoes and vegan chorizo for vegan option)
- Garlic - 2 cloves
- White onion minced ¼
- Oil or Lard - 2-3 Tbsp

For the Salsa:
- Tomatillos 6-8
- Chile No spice: Poblano, Chilaca. Mild: Jalapen. Hot: Serrano. Very Hot: Arbol (dry)
- White onion ¼
- Garlic - 2 cloves
- Cilantro (optional)

Toppings:
- Crema
- Lettuce (Iceberg is the most common one)
- Avocado
- Roma tomato
- Lime

- Queso Fresco (Feta works if you can't find it)

Tools you need:

- Bean presser / Hand Masher (the one used to make mashed potatoes)
- Two plastic films. They can be made out of plastic bags, ziploc bags, parchment paper, or a non-stick paper.
- Tortillera (NOT REQUIRED) helps to make the sopes faster, but I will teach you how to make them by hand.
- Blender/Molcajete. Your choice :)

Prep:

1. Rinse your hibiscus flower. Put it in a pot on medium heat with the water, and sugar for 12 minutes after soft boiling. Once done, let it cool down. Strain into a jar with ice, add water to adjust the flavor.
2. Start by combining the masa and the water. Mix until masa doesn't stick to your hands. You know there is enough water when you make a ball, press it, and the masa doesn't crack. Cover it and let it rest for ~15 minutes.
3. In a pan, start frying your chopped onion, once cooked, remove it. Add your beans, and start mashing them. Let them cook until desired consistency.
4. In another pan, add your oil, garlic and minced onion. Cook until translucent. Add your beef, cover it, and let it cook.
5. After 15 min of resting, start by forming a ball of dough with your hand. With your hand or a tortilla press, put the ball between your non-stick films until you form a 4-5 inch disk.
6. Cook the disk on a hot pan (I will be using teflon). First one side, once the border starts to cook, flip. Wait 30-40 seconds, flip again, making sure this side has brown marks for cooking. Wait 30-40 seconds, set aside.
7. While warm, start shaping your sope by pinching the sides. Additionally, you can fry it on a shallow pool of oil to give it an extra crisp (I will be doing this).
8. For the salsa, you can broil, boil, cook on stove top, or an airfryer. Until lightly brown. Add to blender with some salt.
9. Prepare your toppings by chopping the lettuce, dicing your onions and avocado, and smashing your cheese.
10. Assemble on this order: Sope disk, beans, meat, toppings, crema. Enjoy